

FAIRLINGTON

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EARLY FAIRLINGTON

The first inhabitants of this area were a fairly peaceful group of farmers and fishermen from a tribe of Algonquins named Nescotins. Captain John Smith, exploring the area in 1608, mapped a Nescotin village at the Virginia end of today's 14th Street Bridge. Whether any Nescotin could claim the title of first resident of Fairlington is a matter of conjecture, but the tribe certainly provided Fairlington with its first neighbors.

Captain Smith's explorations of the early 1600's made the Jamestown settlers aware of this region, but the slow start of the Virginia colony and problems with the Indians delayed effective settlement until the 18th Century. In 1722 the Iroquois, who were responsible for most of the problems in the region, ceded to the Europeans all land south of the Potomac and east of the Blue Ridge. This opened the area to settlers, mainly sharecropping tenants and indentured servants working for absentee landlords. The first land patent for the area which includes Fairlington was granted for 543 acres to William Struttfield by Lord Fairfax on January 21, 1705. In 1756, after four transfers in land speculation arrangements, the Struttfield patent was purchased by John Carlyle, the merchant who built the Carlyle House in Alexandria.

Grist mills were needed for the farms of the area so several were built along Four Mile Run. The closest was the Masterson Mill built in the early 1750's near the current intersection of Arlington Mill Drive and Shirlington Road. Another local mill, of more historical importance, was the Carlyle Mill located just below the present West Glebe Road Bridge over Four Mile Run. It was rebuilt by John Carlyle in 1763 on the site of one of the earliest mills in the region, Chubb's Mill(1719), which had been destroyed by fire. One of Carlyle's customers was George Washington, who shipped grain up to the mill by boat - Four Mile Run being navigable at the time - when his own mill was in disrepair.

The real money crop in Colonial Virginia was tobacco; so much so that practically all of what is now Arlington County could be purchased in 1669 with a payment of 672 lbs of tobacco. However, tobacco cultivation tended to wear out the soil so planters were forced to repeatedly push outwards, towards the frontier. Alexandria, being a major tobacco port, found itself the hub of a continually expanding network of "rolling" roads - named for the barrels of tobacco "rolled" along them from tobacco plantations to warehouses or shipping stations. Two such roads were constructed out of Alexandria in the early 18th Century which had an effect on the value of this immediate area. One was built northwest, following an old Indian trail, to reach a tobacco warehouse located near Chain Bridge; its route is followed today by Glebe Road. The other was built due west to intercept the Little River Turnpike. Its last remnants are seen today with Braddock Road, named for the fact that some of General Braddock's forces used the road to travel westward on his ill-fated campaign in 1755.

At the time of the Revolutionary War all of present day Arlington

and Alexandria were part of Fairfax County. Arlington consisted of 15 plantations of 500-1200 acres, owned by such men as George Washington, George Mason, and John Carlyle. All these men were intimately involved in the war, either in the events preceeding it or in the war effort itself. The closest this area came to seeing any real action in the Revolutionary War was the passage of some 1500 Continental and French army troops going to and from the Battle of Yorktown. The Fairfax County Militia was called up several times for local defense, but their only recorded fighting took place away from home in the Battles of Germantown(1777) and Yorktown(1781). The major assistance of the region to the war effort came with its contributions of money, supplies, recruits, and the inspired leadership of George Washington.

Interestingly, the war did have a direct impact on Fairlington. In 1780 John Carlyle died, willing the old Struttfield patent to one of his sons, George William Carlyle. But George Carlyle, who at the age of 17 was an officer in the Continental Army, was killed at the Battle of Eutaw Springs in 1781. His estate was then divided between two nephews; John Carlyle Herbert, one of whose descendants was a co-founder of today's Burke and Herbert Bank in Alexandria, and Carlyle Fairfax Whiting, who inherited the section encompassing Fairlington and who subsequently built its first permanent structure. This structure was thought to have been a large, white frame house located on the knoll overlooking today's I-395 where South 31st Street deadends at Route 7. In 1792, Carlyle Whiting, being a conscientious neighbor, wrote a letter to the owner of the property adjoining his to the north and east advising him of trespassers stealing wood. The letter was to George Washington who had purchased the property in 1774.

In June of 1788 the Constitution of the United States was ratified and provided the Arlington region with its first unique identification. Article I, Section 9 authorized Congress to accept 10 square miles of territory from the states to be the seat of the newly formed federal government. This new Federal Territory in Virginia was officially called "The County of Alexandria of the District of Columbia". A series of boundary markers were set along the entire border of the federal enclave in both Maryland and Virginia. Many of these markers are still in place, although most are in a bad state of repair. One can be seen today on the southern boundary of South Fairlington along Route 7 close to its intersection with South Wakefield Street. All of Fairlington was included in the Federal Territory except the section in North Fairlington which lies southwest of Columbus Street.

It is interesting to speculate what would have become of Arlington, and with it Fairlington, if the federal government had chosen to be based on the Virginia side of the Potomac, rather than Maryland. It is said that this did not occur because George Washington requested no federal buildings be erected in Virginia so as to forstall any hint of impropriety with his large land holdings here. Whatever the reason, without such institutions the Arlington section of Alexandria County remained rural and lightly populated into the first quarter of the 20th Century. The census of 1800 showed the "country" part of Alexandria County had a total population of 978 people, including 297 slaves. The census of 1900 showed a 6 fold increase to

6,430 people, while over this same 100 years the population of the entire United States rose 14 fold.

Starting in 1804, and over the ensuing years, petitions were introduced in Congress requesting the retrocession of Alexandria County to Virginia. These requests were based on economic considerations. The town of Alexandria was dependent on trade for survival, an endeavor which locked it in competition with the merchants of Georgetown. The question of retrocession was to eventually turn on this competitive struggle for markets and the construction of the C&O Canal.

Efforts were made in the early 1830's by Alexandria to have the federal government underwrite the cost of extending the canal over the Potomac to Virginia, but these efforts were blocked by strong lobbying from Georgetown merchants. To add insult to injury, an extension of the canal was eventually built with federal funding, but due to Georgetown influence, this extension was used to terminate the canal at the Anacostia River, entirely bypassing a Potomac terminus accessible by Alexandria.

Beginning in 1831 Alexandria attempted to construct its own access with a canal built northwest out of Alexandria to intercept the C&O above Georgetown. Work was slow and costly; the section from just Alexandria City to Four Mile Run took 5 years. By 1843 the Alexandria Canal was finished; it remained in operation until 1886. The last step was the construction of the Aqueduct Bridge which carried the canal over the Potomac between Georgetown and present day Rosslyn. The remains of this bridge are the last vestiges of the Alexandria Canal and can still be seen today just above Key Bridge. However, from the beginning the canal's operation was plagued with problems which forced the operating company to the verge of bankruptcy time and again. Georgetown merchants blocked any federal financial assistance and Virginia was unwilling to underwrite a project not located within the state. By 1846 the problems of the canal's finances brought the question of retrocession to a head.

With the state of Virginia officially willing to accept the return of the region, a Congressionally authorized public referendum was held in the Alexandria Courthouse on August 17, 1846. The referendum passed, and a month later, by official proclamation from President Polk, Alexandria County was returned to Virginia.

(Note: Two years prior to retrocession George Whiting died and his 640 acre estate was subsequently broken up among his heirs. A 200 acre section, which included most of Fairlington, went to his son, Charles Whiting.)

These early years of the 19th Century were witness to two significant changes in local travel. In 1813 Congress chartered the Leesburg and Alexandria Pike Company to build a turnpike northwest out of Alexandria towards Leesburg. The resulting road was called the Leesburg-Alexandria Turnpike, a name it retained up to the 1950's when it was shortened to the Leesburg Pike. And, the year after retrocession, the Virginia General Assembly chartered the Alexandria

and Harper's Ferry Railroad Company to build a railroad westward out of Alexandria through the Four Mile Run valley. The railroad was in use into the 1950's as part of the Washington and Old Dominion Railroad. Today the section through Four Mile Run is the electric powerline right-of-way along Four Mile Run Drive.

In the early 1830's an interesting social phenomenon occurred in the area. Due partly to its location, but mainly because of its milder weather, Northern Virginia became the "Miami" of that era for Northerners escaping the harsher winters of Pennsylvania and New York. One of these New York "snowbirds" was Hachaliah Bailey who, in 1837, arrived in this area looking for winter quarters for the animals he used in his circus - a predecessor of today's Ringling Brothers, Barnum, and Bailey Circus. He purchased 526 acres at the crossing of the Leesburg and Columbia Turnpikes, a site which eventually took the family name as its own - Baileys Crossroads.

CIVIL WAR FAIRLINGTON

On the night the citizens of Alexandria ratified Virginia's Ordinance of Secession, May 23, 1861, federal troops were dispatched across the Potomac to secure the river's bridges. The wisdom of securing the heights above the bridges was soon recognized, because not only did they overlook the federal positions along the Virginia shoreline, they also exposed the city to possible cannonade. Incredibly, Congress put a halt to the construction of fortifications almost as soon as they were begun in a mistaken belief that the war would soon end and the money spent on such construction would have been wasted. The First Battle of Bull Run on July 21 altered the picture dramatically.

On June 2, a month before First Bull Run, a small scouting party of Confederate troops stumbled into a Union outpost at the Arlington Mill, located at the present intersection of Four Mile Run Drive and Columbia Pike. The fighting resulted in a draw with the Confederate force escaping westward up the Four Mile Run valley, on a railway handcar stolen from the Alexandria and Harpers Ferry Railroad. The fight itself was inconsequential, its only importance was as the closest recorded fighting of the Civil War to Fairlington. (Arlington Mill, built to produce grist for the Arlington Estate in 1836, was destroyed later in the war as an act of retribution against Arlington Estate owner Robert E. Lee.)

The period immediately following First Bull Run was a nerve-wracking one for the Capital. Its forces had been routed, it was surrounded by hostile territory - most of eastern Maryland being pro-South at the time - and Confederate positions in Virginia were just five miles from the Potomac River. The Confederate line was anchored on Munson's Hill, located just off Leesburg Pike, halfway between Baileys Crossroads and Seven Corners. In August the Confederates made their first attempt at probing the Washington defenses by advancing a small force north along today's Lee Highway. They were met by Union forces at Hall's Hill, close to the current intersection of Lee Highway

and Glebe Road. A brisk skirmish ensued which resulted in the Confederate forces being driven back.

In November of 1861 the bulk of Confederate forces withdrew from their Washington positions to more defensible positions around the Fairfax County Courthouse. By that time Washington was surrounded by fixed fortifications and was no longer in its exposed position of four months previous. In Virginia this consisted of redoubts strung along Arlington Heights and was called the Arlington Line. Today this Line would be represented by an arc stretching from Spout Run Parkway, in the north of the county, southward through the County Courthouse and Fort Myer to end at the Navy Annex. The weak point in this line was the southern flank, roughly paralleling today's I-395, where the terrain interrupted an orderly continuation of fortifications. As a result a line of fortifications had to be built southwest to the Leesburg Turnpike and then southeast to Alexandria. One of these fortifications was Fort Reynolds.

Fort Reynolds was an earthen redoubt constructed in September 1861 by German-American troops under the command of Brigadier-General Louis Blenker. It had a perimeter of 360 yards, emplacements for 12 guns and was meant to block any approach on Washington down the Four Mile Run valley. Its artillery complement consisted of 4 32-pounder smooth-bore cannon, 4 12-pounder howitzers, 3 30-pounder Parrot rifled guns, and 2 24-pounder Coehorn mortars. Initially it was named Fort Blenker, but in 1863 it was renamed in honor of Major-General John Fulton Reynolds. Reynolds had been a graduate of West Point, an Indian fighter, and a veteran of both Mexican-American War and early Civil War fighting. He fell on the first day of the Battle of Gettysburg when his brigade made the Union's initial contact with the Confederates at the start of the battle. Up to the 1950's, Fort Reynolds was considered one of the best preserved of Washington's defensive fortifications - old-time Fairlington residents say it was in better shape than Fort Ward in Alexandria. In spite of a generous offer to Arlington County in 1954 by its owner who wished it preserved, the offer was refused and the fort was destroyed during the construction of the Park-Shirlington Apartments in 1955.

In the fall of 1862 a military commission was established in Washington to review the city's fortifications. One of its actions was to order the construction of a small artillery redoubt to protect the flank of Fort Reynolds from possible Confederate attack from positions on Seminary Ridge. This fortification, built in early 1863, was called Battery Garesche. It had a perimeter of 166 yards and emplacements for 8 guns. The Battery was named in honor of two Union officers, brothers, one of whom fell at the Battle of Murfreesboro in Tennessee on December 29, 1862 and the other of whom died just 3 days later at the Battle of Vicksburg. The battery was located close to today's intersection of South Abingdon Street and 30th Road and remained in existence up to the building of Fairlington in 1943.

By the end of the war the Washington defenses were both formidable and extensive, probably built as much to keep the garrison troops occupied as to defend the city. The local section, which was typical

of the 34 mile defensive perimeter of Washington, was anchored on Fort Reynolds went west to Battery Garasche then, turning southwest, continued through a blockhouse and two artillery emplacements to end at Fort Ward, all this plus an interconnecting fortified trench.

POST-CIVIL WAR FAIRLINGTON

The price for Virginia's readmittance to the Union under Reconstruction was the passage, in 1869, of a new state constitution. This constitution was considered an anathema by the traditionalists in Virginia, containing provisions for Negro suffrage, free public education, and, worst of all, requirements for a secret ballot - a blow to the traditionalist conviction that those who were not honorable enough to declare their vote in public were not worthy of its privilege. An additional provision specified that every county in Virginia was to be divided into semi-autonomous districts, excluding all cities with populations of 5000 or more people. As a result the City of Alexandria became a governmental unit independent of the rural Alexandria County. The boundaries of the new Alexandria County were, with some alterations, those of the present day Arlington County.

Around the time of Virginia's Reconstruction, Charles Whiting sold his estate to Courtland Hawkins Smith, a kinsman of Robert E. Lee. A possible factor contributing to the sale was the condition of this region as a result of the Civil War. Fortifications and military roads had disrupted the terrain, acres of woods and orchards had been leveled for fields of fire, many structures had been destroyed or damaged for a variety of reasons, and 10,000 often bored and ill-disciplined troops had been stationed in a region for four years with a total civilian population under 1,500. The results were enormous as reflected in the county's census data for the period between 1860 and 1870. The domestic animal population was halved, the production of grain fell by three-fourths, and the total acreage of improved land fell by one quarter. The impact of Fort Reynolds and Battery Garesche on the immediate area of Whiting's estate can only be imagined. Courtland Smith made his purchase to compliment his city residence in Alexandria. He added acreage from adjacent property, remodeled the Whiting mansion, and named the entire estate "Hampton". The remodeled mansion was torn down in the 1940's to make way for Fairlington's, now removed, water tower. It is said that parts of both the original and remodeled structure's foundation continued to be visible up to the most recent widening of Shirley Highway (I-395) in 1968.

The post-Civil War period, from 1870 to 1900, was to bring sweeping social changes to the county. A map of Alexandria drawn in 1878 could show each individual structure, but by 1900 some of the more populated sections of the county had to be represented by community names. The population doubled from 3000 to 6000, farm acreage in the county dropped from 80% to 50%, subdivisions were begun by real estate operators - the first being Glen Carlyn built next to a well known resort of the period, Carlin Springs, and best of all an improved mode of local transportation was introduced - an electric railway, a boon for commuters when most of the county's roads were still dirt. In

addition a psychological lift was given the county when its government was removed from the City of Alexandria in 1898 to its newly constructed home in the Alexandria County Courthouse on Fort Myer Heights, halfway between Rosslyn and Clarendon, the same site occupied by today's Arlington County government.

In both 1915 and 1929 the City of Alexandria moved to annex part of the county. The 1929 annexation was especially damaging to the county as it moved the city's northern boundary to Four Mile Run. The county sought relief from this creeping annexation in the Virginia General Assembly which passed a special act in 1930 terminating any further annexations of Arlington. Without this act all of Fairlington might well have ended up as part of Alexandria.

In 1920, at the urging of real estate promoters who wished to end the confusion of having an Alexandria City and an Alexandria County, the county petitioned the General Assembly for a name change. The Assembly, struck by the idea of honoring one of its most famous native sons, Robert E. Lee, concurred with the county's wish to be renamed Arlington.

By the turn of the century Hampton had passed to Courtland Hawkins Smith II, under whose stewardship it was to enter its halcyon days as a country estate. In 1899 Courtland Smith II married Carlyle Fairfax Herbert, a direct descendent of John Carlyle - thus returning the estate, at least tangentially, to its owners of 170 years before. Under Courtland Smith II, Hampton became one of America's premier horse farms; breeding hunters, steeple-chasers, and showhorses. He was said to have been the richest man in the area with over 90 thoroughbred brood mares occupying the estate's stables which stood where the Fairlington firehouse is now located. By all accounts Smith was quite the sportsman; organizing and leading the Hampton Hounds, a group of area horsemen devoted to fox hunts, steeplechases, and horse shows. During one such affair at Hampton it is said Smith took a jumper over a six foot hurdle while cradling his six week old daughter. Sources reported three women fainted as a result of this feat. Unfortunately, Mrs. Smith's reaction went unrecorded.

Around 1908 Courtland Smith moved to the Warrenton-Middleburg area in order to pursue his equine passions in a more open and rural atmosphere. Hampton was eventually broken up into several smaller estates when Smith put it up for sale in 1926. The land at that time was all woodland, except for a meadow which lay parallel to the Leesburg Pike in today's South Fairlington. In 1931 the meadow was turned into a private airplane field with a flying school, but in 1934 a fatal crash caused the landing field to be closed at the insistence of nearby residents on Seminary Ridge. In 1941 this same area came under consideration as an auxiliary landing field by the Navy, but this idea was dropped in the face of opposition coming from these same Seminary Ridge residents.

FAIRLINGTON

Late in 1940 the quasi-governmental Defense Homes Corporation was organized by the federal government. Its mission was to build homes for defense workers where private industry could not, or would not; private developers feeling that once World War II was over, the economic base for such projects would be removed and they would be stuck with abandoned housing. The DHC was meant to be a temporary expedient to float loans from the Reconstruction Finance Corporation, a predecessor of the Federal Housing Authority. These loans were to be repayed later less interest, operating expenses and local taxes.

At the time the DHC was being chartered, two major construction projects were undertaken locally which directly effected the building of Fairlington. One was the building of a highway south from Washington. This highway had been originally conceived as a result of the Bonus Army March on Washington in 1932, when the need was seen for a roadway which would ensure the prompt deployment of U.S. Army troops stationed at Fort Belvoir in Virginia to Washington. However, besides making the city more accessible from the countryside, the new Henry G. Shirley Memorial Highway also had the opposite effect of making that same countryside more accessible from the city. The second project was the building of the Pentagon as the nation's armed services headquarters. The manpower requirements of this mammoth office building far exceeded the available local housing, so the White House in early 1941 urged the Metropolitan Life Insurance Company to underwrite the construction of a 1700 unit garden style apartment complex just off the new Shirley Highway in what was then Fairfax County. This complex was one of the first real estate projects underwritten by life insurance equity in the nation and took the name Park-Fairfax. It was soon realized though, that Park-Fairfax was inadequate to meet the housing requirements imposed by the area's growing involvement in the the war effort.

In late 1941 the DHC moved to acquire a tract in Arlington County across from the Park-Fairfax site to provide more defense housing. The acquisition was announced on February 5, 1942. Newspapers seemed to have had a hard time in understanding the exact scope or location of the project, reporting it as a 1000(?) unit endeavor and placing its location on the Duke Street(?) boundary between Arlington and Fairfax. The tract consisted of 342 acres acquired from half a dozen property owners. When the construction crews moved onto the tract at the beginning of 1942, their first task was to move one of Washington's World War II defensive anti-aircraft batteries from the old landing field in South Fairlington to a new location off the Leesburg Turnpike opposite North Fairlington. Unit construction began in the south and proceeded north. At the time, the Seminary Ridge Project, as Fairlington was then called, was the largest housing project under development in the United States. The prime construction contractor was the Thompson Starrett Company, the chief architect was Kenneth Franzheim, and, according to an oral report, the subcontractor responsible for Fairlington's brickwork was a Mr. Jack Kelly of Philadelphia, who would occassionally travel down to the worksite accompanied by his young daughter, Grace.

as large as Fairlington with its very strict wartime rent controls. The project went begging until 1947, when a new offering was created, composed of Fairlington, McLean Gardens, and a small project located in Washington State. Ready with a down payment check of \$4 million was a high-flying real estate tycoon from Dallas, Texas - Leo Corrigan, and his Texas oilman partner - Leland Fikes. The papers for the properties were signed in February of 1947. The mortgage was for 28 years on \$43 million at 2 1/2% interest. It is estimated that Fairlington represented \$33 million of the total package, \$2 million less than the project cost, but only \$7,000 less than the appraised book value; the DHC was later to report a profit of \$1 million on Fairlington. After the deal was consummated, Messrs. Corrigan and Fikes formed a limited partnership, deriving its name from those of the two largest complexes - FAIRlington and McLean Gardens - FAIRMAC.

The social life of Fairlington during this early period revolved around highly structured volunteer organizations such as the PTA, the Red Cross, etc., and the celebration of holidays and local events. Especially notable were the Memorial Day bike parades, the All State's parties, Christmas parties, and, in May of 1953, the highly successful 10th Anniversary Celebration which featured representatives from both the Alexandria and Arlington governments, a parade, and a baseball game between the north and south Cub Scout packs. Fairlingtonians were also very active in local political affairs, and through such organizations as the Better Government League, and its later successor, Arlingtonians for a Better County (ABC), were instrumental in the success of county political reform movements in the late 1940s and mid-1950s.

Besides social stability, there was also social change. In 1949 the effects of the postwar baby boom began to be felt within the community. To cope with it the Fairmac Corporation deeded to the county some unused land which the county used to erect Abingdon School, opening it in 1950. Some time later in the decade another change came when CORE picketed to have Fairmac drop Fairlington's color barrier. In response to two days of such activity the restriction was removed, but the Black population of Fairlington was not to rise above 1% until after its conversion to condominiums some 20 years later.

In the late 1950s Corrigan and Fikes began experiencing difficulties in their partnership due to their separate philosophies concerning how Fairmac's property should be managed. For real estate man Corrigan the name of the game was profits, but for oilman Fikes it was tax deductions. This difference came to a head in mid-1959. By prior arrangement at noon on June 15, the two partners met in the office of the president of the Mercantile National Bank in Dallas. They had each submitted sealed bids to the president for the Fairmac Corporation, agreeing that whichever partner had submitted the higher bid would buy out the other for the bid price. However, when the bank president opened the bids he found them to be identical. To resolve the problem, the partners agreed to have the bank president flip a silver dollar; the winner would get the corporation, the loser would get all the cash currently in the partnership's bank account.

Fikes won the toss and took over as sole proprietor of

Fairlington. He immediately acted to replace Corrigan's management with his own, moving two of his oil company executives from Dallas to Northern Virginia to do so: J.D. Lee and Walter Hodges. To sweeten the pot for them, Fikes included as part of their job benefits stock in the Fairmac corporation. In 1966 Fikes died leaving an estate which took his heirs two years to settle. In 1968 Fike's heirs sold their interest in Fairmac to the Hartford Insurance Company.

As the years progressed into the 1960s, Fairlington began to experience a decline as its tax advantages started to expire and its physical plant became increasingly more expensive to maintain. These two factors, coupled with a highly transient population, led to a slow physical and social deterioration of the community. By the late 1960s there were increasing fears about crime, the average income of the Fairlington family was in decline, and Fairlington was losing its reputation as a pleasant place to live. This does not mean the community had died, it was still able to throw a good Memorial Day celebration as late as 1971. But the development was in need of a good facelift, either by restoration or renovation. On April 28, 1972, Walter Hodges announced plans to renovate South Fairlington rental units for sale as condominiums. The renovation was to retain the original Williamsburg exteriors, but dramatic interiors were created through the architectural work of Steven Calhoun Smith, currently chief architect of the National Episcopal Cathedral. Under the original plan the northern sections was to remain rental. The announcement of conversion was well received by both Fairlington renters, who could still rent in at least part of the community, and by the surrounding community, as a means of turning back Fairlington's decay and benefiting the county's tax base. Fairlington's renovation, like its construction some 30 years prior, was to be one of the nation's largest such undertakings. The first units converted to condominiums had an average price tag of \$35,000; so affordable that 73% of them were purchased by Fairlington tenants.

In December of 1972, Hartford Insurance announced the sale of its interest in Fairmac to the Chicago Bridge and Iron Works Corporation (CBI). By 1979 CBI had also purchased the Fairmac stock held by Messrs. Lee and Hodges, making it sole owner of the corporation.

By 1974 the average price of a converted unit in Fairlington had risen to \$43,000, which began to place some of the units out of the financial reach of many renters. In May of that year the now renamed CBI Fairmac Corporation announced their plan of extending the conversion into the northern section of the community. This 1974 announcement did not meet with the same approval as the one in 1972. Feelings ran high as the renters, especially the elderly ones, saw their chances for continuing to live in Fairlington nullified by rising unit prices and the expanding conversion. Fairmac had to resort to evictions, engendering more bad feelings as tenants challenged both the evictions and the north side conversion through petition drives, lobbying with local elected officials, and forcing hearings before the Virginia Real Estate Commission. In the end, agreements were reached wherein some eviction delays were granted and Fairmac agreed to

distribute funds for relocation expenses.

By June of 1976 the last renter had left Fairlington, and on July 30, 1977, after the expenditure of \$100 million, the conversion of Fairlington was considered complete. The average cost of a unit by that time had risen to \$51,000. On the south side the community was divided into six independent condominium villages, each with its own governing board of directors elected by homeowners. The northern side was not so divided, by tradition this is because of the problems envisioned in managing the community center and the central tennis courts.

The conversion was to bring the community full cycle from where it had begun in 1943. As in 1943 the typical resident was again to be highly educated - 67% of current Fairlingtonians have a college degree or better, highly skilled - 66% occupy either a managerial or professional position, and highly paid - 79% of Fairlington's families earn \$25,000 or more per year. Residents again take pride in being Fairlingtonians - some who remember it from the 1940s compare it favorably with that period. Its history, its architectural styling, and its beauty, but mainly its residents, all contribute to the uniqueness that is Fairlington.

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